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THE LEAD

US Embassies Across the Mideast Tell Americans: Be Ready to Leave

Five months into the Iran war, a fragile strike pause and a newly unveiled Gaza disarmament roadmap arrive as Washington and Tehran cannot even agree that talks exist.

US POLITICS

Blanche's AG Nomination Stalls Over DOJ "Anti-Weaponization" Fund

Sens. John Cornyn (R-TX) and Thom Tillis (R-NC) are withholding their votes on Todd Blanche's confirmation as attorney general until the Justice Department puts in writing an enforceable commitment to kill a \$1.8 billion fund — one that also granted President Trump personal tax-audit immunity. Trump said Friday the fund is "dead, but I wish it weren't," stopping short of the written rescission the holdouts are demanding. The Senate Judiciary Committee has delayed its scheduled vote on advancing the nomination.

WHY IT MATTERS

A verbal promise from the executive branch is not a legal constraint. Cornyn is testing whether Senate Republicans, in a chamber they control, will accept anything less than a written, enforceable rescission — the difference between a norm and a loophole that outlives this administration.

CBS News — [cbsnews.com/news/todd-blanche-nomination-trump-attorney-general-on-hold-doj-anti-weaponization-fund](https://www.cbsnews.com/news/todd-blanche-nomination-trump-attorney-general-on-hold-doj-anti-weaponization-fund)

Regulators Move to Gut the Anti-Redlining Rulebook

The Office of the Comptroller of the Currency and the FDIC jointly proposed changes Friday to the 1977 Community Reinvestment Act. The overhaul would shrink the number of banks fully subject to the law's lending-to-low-and-moderate-income-neighborhoods requirements, and would discourage banks from making grants to national community organizations in favor of local ones.

WHY IT MATTERS

Fewer banks under full CRA scrutiny means less enforceable pressure to lend in the neighborhoods the law was written to protect. This is a quiet deregulatory move against a fifty-year-old civil-rights-era statute, executed through rulemaking rather than legislation.

Baltimore Sun — [baltimoresun.com/2026/07/31/community-reinvestment-act-overhaul](https://www.baltimoresun.com/2026/07/31/community-reinvestment-act-overhaul)

SCOTUS & THE JUDICIARY

This Term's Executive-Power Rulings Still Setting the Frame

In late June the Court overturned a 91-year-old precedent by a 6-3 vote, holding that President Trump's 2025 firing of FTC Commissioner Rebecca Kelly Slaughter without cause was lawful — a major expansion of presidential control over agencies once designed to be insulated from the White House. Separately, a 5-4 majority (Chief Justice Roberts, the Court's three liberal justices, and Justice Kavanaugh) allowed Federal Reserve Governor Lisa Cook to keep her seat for now.

WHY IT MATTERS

The Slaughter ruling is the bigger story long-term. It narrows the independent-agency doctrine that has structured the administrative state since Humphrey's Executor in 1935 — a precedent line, not a single agency, is what actually fell.

NPR — [npr.org/2026/06/09/nx-s1-5847967/supreme-court-major-cases-left-2026](https://www.npr.org/2026/06/09/nx-s1-5847967/supreme-court-major-cases-left-2026)

Court Takes Up an Eighth Amendment Forfeiture Case

The Court granted certiorari in *Jouppi v. Alaska*, which asks whether courts may weigh the gravity of an underlying offense purely in the abstract when deciding whether a fine or forfeiture — here, the seizure of a 1969 Cessna — violates the Excessive Fines Clause.

WHY IT MATTERS

A narrow-sounding property case that will shape how aggressively state and federal governments can use civil forfeiture nationwide, regardless of the underlying offense's severity.

Reason (Volokh Conspiracy) — reason.com/volokh/2026/07/20/scotus-granted-a-petition-on-july-20-that-was-conferenced-on-june-29

ISRAEL & THE MIDDLE EAST

Embassies Across the Region Tell Citizens: Be Ready to Leave

Citing the "potential for unforeseen escalation," US missions in Jerusalem and other regional capitals are urging Americans to avoid travel to the Middle East and be prepared to depart, five months into the 2026 Iran war. Strikes have been paused since late July to allow talks to develop, but Iran says no negotiations are currently underway. Strait of Hormuz shipping fell to fewer than ten commodity vessels over the weekend.

ANALYTICAL READ

Washington is framing the pause as diplomacy-in-progress while Tehran denies any talks exist — a messaging gap suggesting either wishful framing by the US or a channel neither side wants to confirm publicly. Five months on, a campaign that began under a self-defense rationale for strikes on Iranian military sites has become an open-ended confrontation with no stated endpoint, and the durable cost — collapsed shipping, regional economic paralysis — is being paid by neither government directly.

The Times of Israel — timesofisrael.com/liveblog-august-01-2026

Board of Peace Releases Full Gaza Disarmament-and-Withdrawal Roadmap

The document, built on President Trump's peace plan and UN Security Council Resolution 2803, sets a phased, internationally verified sequence: Israel halts strikes, a 14-day clock begins on transferring civilian and security control to a new National Committee for the Administration of Gaza, and progress from phase to phase depends on verified completion of the prior phase, monitored by an International Verification Committee. A diplomatic source separately told the Jerusalem Post that the IDF will not leave its current Yellow Line position before Hamas fully disarms.

ANALYTICAL READ

That IDF line is sourced to an unnamed Israeli-linked official, not the text of the agreement — treat it as Israel pre-positioning its own leverage over the sequencing fight, not a neutral read of the roadmap's requirements. Every prior Gaza ceasefire has broken down at exactly this joint: who moves first, and who certifies the other side moved enough. Whoever controls the pace controls the leverage, and right now that is Israel.

The Times of Israel — timesofisrael.com/full-text-of-board-of-peace-deal-for-hamas-to-disarm-israel-to-withdraw-from-gaza

ITALY, ROME & THE VATICAN

Vatican Declares the Society of St. Pius X in Schism

On July 1, SSPX bishops Bernard Fellay and Alfonso de Galarreta consecrated four priests to the episcopate in Ecône, Switzerland, without a papal mandate and against Pope Leo XIV's explicit will. The next day, Cardinal Victor Manuel Fernandez, Prefect of the Dicastery for the Doctrine of the Faith, signed a decree declaring the consecrations "an act of a schismatic nature." An accompanying Explanatory Note goes further, stating that every sacred minister belonging to the SSPX worldwide "must therefore be considered schismatic" and falls under the automatic excommunication prescribed by Canon 1364. The note extends comparable treatment to lay faithful who formally adhere to the Society, and declares SSPX confessions and marriages invalid.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is not discipline against four bishops. The Explanatory Note attempts to settle, in a single document, the canonical status of an entire worldwide priestly society founded in 1970 — the sharpest rupture between Rome and the SSPX since Archbishop Lefebvre's own 1988 excommunication for the identical offense.

America Magazine — americamagazine.org/vatican-dispatch/2026/07/02/vatican-excommunicates-sspx-bishops-priests-and-some-lay-faithful

Pope Leo XIV Heads to Assisi for the "Go! Franciscan Youth Meeting"

After a July rest at Castel Gandolfo, the Pope resumes public Masses and audiences every week of August, beginning with a trip to Assisi from August 3 to 6. He is scheduled to fly by helicopter from the Vatican on the morning of August 3, and on August 6 will meet young people aged 18 to 33 at the Basilica of Santa Maria degli Angeli for a period of listening before presiding at a solemn Eucharistic celebration. Organizers are reprising a line the Pope gave young people during last year's Jubilee: "Our hope is Jesus." He is also set to celebrate Mass on August 15 for the Solemnity of the Assumption.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is Leo XIV's first extended, direct outreach to a pan-European youth audience since his election — deliberately timed to the Franciscan patrimony of Assisi rather than staged at St. Peter's.

Vatican News — vaticannews.va/en/pope/news/2026-07/pope-st-francis-assisi-young-people-mass-august-castel-gandolfo

Drone Hits US-Owned Gas Tanker in Egypt — First Strike on Egyptian Soil in This War

A drone struck the US-owned LNG storage vessel Energos Winter at Egypt's Damietta port on July 30, and the resulting fire spread to a second tanker, the Bermuda-flagged Gaslog Salem. Both crews were evacuated; no injuries were reported. Iranian state television had named Damietta as a possible retaliation target two days earlier, following a Ukrainian strike on an Iranian vessel in the Caspian Sea. No side has claimed responsibility.

ANALYTICAL READ

This is the clearest evidence yet that a war framed in Washington and Jerusalem as self-defense against Iran has metastasized into a multi-front economic conflict that neither the US nor Israel controls the escalation ladder on. Egypt has no stake in the original dispute and is now absorbing the blast radius of a fight it tried to stay out of.

Euronews — euronews.com/2026/07/30/drone-hits-us-lng-vessel-at-damietta-in-first-attack-on-egyptian-soil

RESEARCH & LONG READS

Will Iran Break MAGA?

Eli McKown-Dawson, writing on Nate Silver's Substack, traces how the Iran war has split the American right along generational and ideological lines: younger MAGA voters, shaped by memories of Iraq and Afghanistan, are markedly more skeptical of intervention than the older base, while figures like Tucker Carlson argue Israel is pulling Washington into a war against its own interests. Directly relevant to today's Blanche standoff and the Iran war coverage above — this is the intellectual fault line running underneath both stories.

WHY IT MATTERS

If this generational rift hardens rather than heals, it reshapes the coalition Republicans need to hold together through the 2026 midterms and beyond.

Nate Silver / Silver Bulletin — natesilver.net/p/will-iran-break-maga

Apostolic Succession Is Assurance of Truth

Catholic Answers Magazine defends the doctrine that ecclesial authority passes validly from the apostles through an unbroken chain of episcopal ordination — and that this chain, not private judgment, is what guarantees doctrinal continuity in the Church. Read against today's SSPX story above: the entire canonical argument for the SSPX bishops' excommunication rests on the claim that valid holy orders, conferred without a mandate from the legitimate successor of Peter, still place a minister outside the Church's unity.

WHY IT MATTERS

The SSPX crisis is, at bottom, a live and consequential dispute over exactly what this essay sets out to defend.

Catholic Answers Magazine — catholic.com/magazine/online-edition/apostolic-succession-is-assurance-of-truth